Monday Nite Footballers Commentary

By Jim Nunnelly and
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Don Steadman To Play Major Role In Chief's Minority Hiring Program

It is the job of a vice president to make sure that the organization's daily efforts support the bigger, important corporate mission. Don Steadman has always supported and believed in missions. Before we get into that part of his life, let's look in on Don and see just how he's going to handle the task of overseeing the Kansas City Chiefs' recently-released statement of cooperation with the local NAACP. The announcement of the agreement was published in last week's **KC CALL**. It was the first time that a National Football League team announced its intention to be more conscious of the total minority community in hiring and purchasing. Don's the man with this gigantic task.

To begin, we should explain Don Steadman's role in the Chiefs football organization. He is vice president for administration. Starting out in various sales and promotions, Don's rise to the front office has been somewhat faster than usual. In fact, some say his elevation is directly tied to the fact that his father is Jack Steadman, the Chiefs' all business-like president.

And Don doesn't highlight nor hide his feelings about that fact, either. He's open, candid, and gentle about it all. Calling it a "mixed blessing," he attributes his five year rise at least partly to his father's position. But, he's quick to point out that he does have a great relationship with his father. In meetings and in business affairs, he refers to his dad as "Jack." Obviously, there is a slight sense of discomfort in this first name, front-office familiarity. And, Don surely knows Jack is boss and the younger Steadman strives to complement his father and the business. Wishing to talk more about the Chiefs' minority plan, he switches the focus and talks confidently about the specifics of the plan. What's going to make this a moderately ambitious, pace setting plan work?

Don believes it will work [illegible] NAACP. Jack Steadman and Chiefs' owner Lamar Hunt want it to work. Don asserts that the Chiefs' organization will definitely be more "minority conscious." When they have need for resources—either personnel or supplies, they will consider and focus toward the Kansas City minority market. In the past, he admits that the Chiefs have always [illegible] ized "good ol' boy" networks. Basically, because of the agreement and with this new focus, Don trusts that the number of minority personnel will increase over the next few years.

Currently, the Chiefs employ four out of a front office staff of sixty-five, not including hourly ground workers. And, it is solely

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Don's responsibility to implement, oversee, and advocate the changes, agreed to by the Chiefs and the NAACP. And he smiles widely and proudly when he talks about the Minority Intern program. Under this project, a college student will get in early on the job knowledge and experience, and then receive a higher assignment, once out of college. Already, one key position has been earmarked for a certain minority when he graduates in a year or so. And Don goes on and on. Excitingly about all the possibilities and how it all seems "fair." And the mission side of him intensifies.

By now, his corporate pride is glowing. Especially when he greets the ten potential minority scholarship recipients. They're visiting the Chiefs office for potential financial recognition. He seems to say that this scholarship component is all a part of the corporate commitment to this mission. It's all a part of the minority emphasis mission.

Speaking of mission, let's see now how Don has always been supportive of and believe in missions. Prior to joining the Chiefs organization, Don was a youth minister for a Leawood Baptist Church. There he was a "people-person," equipped to deal with all difficult people assignments. And he had an uncanny ability to successfully implement these kind of missions. And, he's got it now. And, we Monday Niters believe that he'll nurture this program with the same faith, grace, and tenacity that he did back then, at the Johnson County church. All in spite of the criticism and pitfalls that he will experience in this effort.

Face it! It's a job for a man with a sense of mission. Don Steadman has it.

Thank God for that.

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